MODULE 26 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Confusion pairs – twenty things that look alike

No new facts. One question per pair, and the answer in a line.

DOMAIN All five WEIGHT 100% MODULE 26 of 31

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Almost every wrong answer on this exam is the **other half of a pair**. Learn the pairs and you eliminate distractors on sight.

Pairs 1 to 4: tables and objects

THE PAIR	THE ONE QUESTION THAT SEPARATES THEM
Transient or temporary?	Must it outlive the session? Temporary dies with it. Neither has Fail-safe.
Materialized view or dynamic table?	Is any lag acceptable? No lag means MV. A join means dynamic table.
Secure view or ordinary view?	Does anyone outside see it? Only secure views can be shared.
Iceberg or external table?	Do you need to write? Iceberg can. External tables cannot.

ON THE EXAM

Modules 4 and 15. The materialized view versus dynamic table pair is the most frequently tested on this slide.

Pairs 5 to 8: access and security

THE PAIR	THE ONE QUESTION THAT SEPARATES THEM
SECURITYADMIN or SYSADMIN?	Is it a grant or an object? SECURITYADMIN grants. SYSADMIN creates. Neither does the other.
Account role or database role?	Can it be used with USE ROLE? Only account roles. Database roles must be granted to one.
Network rule or network policy?	Which is enforced? The policy. A rule is a list, and does nothing until a policy uses it.
Key rotation or rekeying?	Is existing data re-encrypted? Rotation, no. Rekeying, yes, and it needs Enterprise.

ON THE EXAM

Modules 8 and 9. The first row is the one candidates guess at most, and it is pure recall.

Pairs 9 to 12: monitoring and compute

THE PAIR	THE ONE QUESTION THAT SEPARATES THEM
ACCOUNT_USAGE or INFORMATION_SCHEMA?	How far back, how fresh? A year with lag, or 7 days with none.
Resource monitor or budget?	Is it serverless? Monitors cannot see serverless. Budgets can.
SUSPEND or SUSPEND_IMMEDIATE?	Do running statements finish? SUSPEND waits. IMMEDIATE cancels.
Maximized or auto-scale?	Does min equal max? If so, the scaling policy is ignored.

ON THE EXAM

Modules 11 and 17. Row two is the one that costs money in real accounts, not just marks.

Pairs 13 to 16: loading

THE PAIR	THE ONE QUESTION THAT SEPARATES THEM
Snowpipe or Snowpipe Streaming?	Files or rows? A minute, or seconds.
Standard or append-only stream?	Need deletes and updates? Append-only records inserts only.
VALIDATION_MODE or VALIDATE?	Forwards or backwards? Files not yet loaded, or a past COPY.
ABORT_STATEMENT or SKIP_FILE?	Which command? Bulk COPY default, or Snowpipe's.

ON THE EXAM

Modules 14 and 15. Row four is the same option with two different defaults, which is exactly why it gets tested.

Pairs 17 to 20: performance and collaboration

THE PAIR	THE ONE QUESTION THAT SEPARATES THEM
Clustering or search optimization?	A range or a needle? Ranges cluster. Point lookups need the access path.
Result cache or warehouse cache?	Does it survive suspension? Cloud services yes, warehouse no.
Time Travel or Fail-safe?	Can you do it yourself? Time Travel yes. Fail-safe is Support only.
Direct share or listing?	Is a region boundary crossed? A direct share cannot cross one.

ON THE EXAM

Modules 18, 20, 23 and 24. All four have appeared as full scenarios earlier.

Three-way confusions

THE THREE	HOW TO SEPARATE THEM
Masking, row access, projection	Values, rows, or presence in the output. Three different questions.
@~, @%table, @stage	User, table, named. Tilde, percent, bare name.
Result, metadata, warehouse cache	Two in cloud services, one on the warehouse. That decides everything else.
Storage, API, notification, catalog	Buckets, HTTPS endpoints, cloud messaging, Iceberg catalogs. Never interchangeable.

ON THE EXAM

Four groups where the exam offers all three or four members as options. Row one is the most frequently tested.

The same word, meaning different things

- **Secure** is a property, not an object type. Secure views, secure UDFs, and Tri-Secret Secure are three different things.
- **Refresh** means a materialized view updating, a dynamic table rebuilding, a pipe rescanning a stage, and a failover group syncing.
- **Stage** is a file location. A **staging table** is an ordinary table. They are unrelated.
- **Clustering** means both the automatic ordering of data and the CLUSTER BY key you define. Natural clustering exists without a key.
- **Share** is an object, a verb, and half of Secure Data Sharing. Read which one a question means.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Where a term is overloaded, the question's other nouns tell you which meaning applies. Read them before choosing.

> A team needs a derived dataset joining two large tables, refreshed automatically, with no more than a few minutes of staleness. They also want a second derived dataset over a single table that must be exactly current at all times.
>
> Both accounts are Enterprise Edition.

Which objects fit the two requirements?

A. Materialized views for both, since both are derived and automatically maintained.

B. Dynamic tables for both, since dynamic tables support any query a materialized view does.

C. A materialized view for the join, and a dynamic table for the single-table one.

D. A dynamic table for the join, and a materialized view for the single-table one.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which objects fit the two requirements?

A Materialized views for both.

A materialized view cannot join. The first requirement rules it out immediately.

B Dynamic tables for both.

Dynamic tables have a minimum target lag of 1 minute. 'Exactly current at all times' rules them out for the second.

C MV for the join, dynamic table for the single table.

Both the wrong way round. This is the option for someone who knows the pair exists and cannot remember which way it runs.

D Dynamic table for the join, MV for the single table.

A join forces the dynamic table; zero staleness forces the materialized view. Each requirement points at exactly one object.

THE SIGNAL

Pair 2. Two requirements, deliberately opposite, so you cannot answer with a single preference. C is the trap for half-knowledge.

> A security engineer is asked to stop connections from outside the corporate network, and separately to make sure a new analyst can be created and granted a role by the platform team without involving an account administrator.
>
> They create a network rule listing the office range, and grant SYSADMIN to the platform team's role.

What did they get wrong?

A The network rule needs no policy, but SYSADMIN cannot create users. USERADMIN is required.

B The rule must be added to a network policy and activated, and SYSADMIN cannot create users. USERADMIN or higher is needed.

C Both are correct. Network rules are self-enforcing and SYSADMIN includes user management.

D The network policy is right, but user creation requires ACCOUNTADMIN and cannot be delegated.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What did they get wrong?

A. Rule needs no policy; SYSADMIN cannot create users.

Right about SYSADMIN, wrong about the rule. A rule is a list and enforces nothing on its own.

B. Both wrong. Policy needed, and USERADMIN needed.

Two pairs, both got the wrong way round. A rule needs a policy to enforce it, and user creation lives on the USERADMIN branch.

C. Both are correct.

Neither is. This is the option for someone who has not met either pair.

D. User creation needs ACCOUNTADMIN.

USERADMIN exists precisely so that user management can be delegated without granting ACCOUNTADMIN.

THE SIGNAL

Pairs 5 and 7 together. Getting one right and one wrong lands you on A, which is why partial knowledge is dangerous here.

> An operations team wants an alert when any query exceeds ten minutes, raised within a few minutes of it happening. They also want a quarterly report of every query run against a table over the past nine months, including two tables since dropped.
>
> An architect proposes building both on the same view.

What should each use?

A ACCOUNT_USAGE for both, since it holds a full year and is the authoritative source.

B INFORMATION_SCHEMA for both, since it has no latency and QUERY_HISTORY exists in it.

C INFORMATION_SCHEMA for the alert, ACCOUNT_USAGE for the quarterly report.

D ACCOUNT_USAGE for the alert, INFORMATION_SCHEMA for the quarterly report.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should each use?

A ACCOUNT_USAGE for both.

Latency of 45 minutes to 3 hours makes an alert within a few minutes impossible. Right for the report, wrong for the alert.

B INFORMATION_SCHEMA for both.

Its QUERY_HISTORY holds 7 days and excludes dropped objects. Both halves of the report fail.

C INFORMATION_SCHEMA for the alert, ACCOUNT_USAGE for the report.

No latency for the operational need; a year of history plus dropped objects for the audit. Each requirement matched to its strength.

D The other way round.

Both wrong. This is the option for someone who knows the pair and has it inverted.

THE SIGNAL

Pair 9. The architect's instinct to use one view for both is the real error. The pair exists because you cannot have both properties.

A pipeline uses a stream and a task to apply changes from a source table into a reporting table. Deletions in the source are not reaching the reporting table, while inserts arrive correctly.

Separately, the team's Snowpipe ingestion silently skips whole files when one row is malformed, and nobody has changed any settings.

What explains the two behaviours?

A. An append-only stream records inserts only, and Snowpipe's ON_ERROR defaults to SKIP_FILE.

B. A standard stream ignores deletes, and Snowpipe defaults to ABORT_STATEMENT.

C. The stream went stale, and Snowpipe's default is CONTINUE.

D. The task lacks DELETE privilege, and someone set ON_ERROR = SKIP_FILE manually.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What explains the two behaviours?

A Append-only stream, and SKIP_FILE is Snowpipe's default.

Both behaviours are documented defaults working correctly. Inserts arriving while deletes do not is the append-only signature.

B Standard stream ignores deletes; ABORT_STATEMENT default.

Inverted twice. A standard stream tracks deletes, and ABORT_STATEMENT is the bulk COPY default, not Snowpipe's.

C The stream went stale; CONTINUE is the default.

Staleness loses everything unconsumed, not just deletes. CONTINUE is neither command's default.

D Missing privilege, and someone set SKIP_FILE.

The scenario says nobody changed settings, and a privilege failure would raise an error rather than silently dropping deletes.

THE SIGNAL

Pairs 14 and 16. Neither behaviour is a fault. Both are defaults nobody chose, which is the recurring shape of this exam.

A warehouse is capped by a resource monitor with a suspend trigger. When it fires mid-afternoon, several long-running analytical queries are killed outright, losing hours of work.

Separately, the same account's Snowpipe and automatic clustering spending has grown steadily and the monitor has never reacted to it.

What explains both, and what should change?

A The monitor uses SUSPEND, which cancels running statements. Serverless spending is capped separately by lowering the quota.

B The monitor uses SUSPEND_IMMEDIATE, which cancels statements. Monitors cannot see serverless spending at all; use a budget.

C Both are the same cause: the quota is too low. Raising it fixes the killed queries and the serverless overspend.

D Neither is expected. Resource monitors never cancel statements and always include serverless credits.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What explains both, and what should change?

A SUSPEND cancels statements; lower the quota for serverless.

SUSPEND waits for running statements to finish. And no quota change makes a monitor see serverless spending.

B SUSPEND_IMMEDIATE cancels; use a budget for serverless.

Two pairs, both correct. SUSPEND_IMMEDIATE cancels running statements, and budgets are the documented tool for serverless and AI spend.

C One cause: the quota is too low.

Raising the quota delays the trigger and never makes serverless credits visible to a monitor.

D Neither behaviour is expected.

Both are documented. SUSPEND_IMMEDIATE cancels by design, and the serverless blind spot is stated explicitly.

THE SIGNAL

Pairs 10 and 11. Two independent behaviours in one scenario, and both are working as documented.

A provider builds a view filtering their customer table to one partner's rows and adds it to a share. The share is created successfully but the view cannot be added.

Once that is resolved, they discover the partner's account is in a different cloud region from theirs.

What is needed for each problem?

A Make the view materialized, and enable Cross-Cloud Auto-Fulfillment on the direct share.

B Make the view secure, and add the partner account to the existing direct share.

C Nothing for the view; grant IMPORTED PRIVILEGES, and use replication for the region.

D Make the view secure, and use a listing, since a direct share cannot cross a region boundary.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is needed for each problem?

A Materialize the view; auto-fulfill the direct share.

Secure is the missing property, not materialized. And auto-fulfillment belongs to listings, not to direct shares.

B Secure the view; add the account to the direct share.

Right about the view. Adding an out-of-region account to a direct share is accepted and delivers nothing.

C The view is fine; grant IMPORTED PRIVILEGES.

A non-secure view cannot be added to a share at all, so the first half fails before privileges matter.

D Secure the view, and use a listing.

Only secure views can be shared, and only a listing crosses a region boundary. Each problem gets its own fix.

THE SIGNAL

Pairs 3 and 20. B is the near-miss: correct on the view, and quietly wrong on the region.

> A team uses a transient table for a nightly staging step to save on storage. A developer drops it by mistake at 09:00. At 11:00 they ask whether the data can be recovered.
>
> The table used the default retention setting. The account is on Enterprise Edition.

What is the position?

A. UNDROP should work. A transient table gets 1 day of Time Travel by default, and Fail-safe does not apply to it.

B. Nothing can be done. Transient tables have no Time Travel at all.

C. UNDROP will fail, but Snowflake Support can recover it from the 7-day Fail-safe window.

D. Enterprise gives 90 days of Time Travel, so the table can be recovered at any point in the next three months.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the position?

A UNDROP works. 1 day of Time Travel, no Fail-safe.

Transient tables support 0 or 1 day, defaulting to 1. Two hours is well inside it, and Fail-safe correctly does not apply.

B Transient tables have no Time Travel.

They have 0 or 1 day. It is Fail-safe they lack entirely, which is a different thing.

C Fail-safe can recover it.

Fail-safe covers permanent objects only. Its absence is exactly why transient storage is cheaper.

D Enterprise gives 90 days.

90 days applies to permanent tables. A transient table tops out at 1 day whatever the edition.

THE SIGNAL

Pairs 1 and 19. Both distractors confuse 'no Fail-safe' with 'no Time Travel'. Transient has one and not the other.

A multi-cluster warehouse is configured with MIN_CLUSTER_COUNT and MAX_CLUSTER_COUNT both set to 3, and AUTO_SUSPEND set to 60 seconds. It serves a dashboard used in bursts through the day.

The bill is high, and users report that the first queries after any quiet spell are noticeably slow.

What explains the two symptoms?

A The scaling policy is set to Economy, which keeps clusters running and delays new ones.

B Three clusters share one local disk cache, so cache misses are inevitable.

C Min equals max, so all three clusters run whenever it is up. And suspending drops the warehouse cache.

D The result cache is being cleared on suspend, so every burst recomputes from scratch.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What explains the two symptoms?

A The scaling policy is Economy.

With min equal to max the warehouse is Maximized, and the scaling policy is ignored entirely.

B Three clusters share one cache.

Invented. Each cluster has its own local storage; they do not contend over a shared cache.

C Maximized mode, and suspend drops the warehouse cache.

Both symptoms explained. Three clusters bill continuously, and a 60-second auto-suspend throws the local cache away repeatedly.

D The result cache is cleared on suspend.

The result cache lives in cloud services and survives suspension. It is the warehouse cache that is lost.

THE SIGNAL

Pairs 12 and 18. Two settings, two symptoms, and the result-cache option is there for anyone who has the caches the wrong way round.

How to use this module

- **Rewatch this one the day before.** It is deliberately dense and contains nothing you have not already met.
- **Cover the right-hand column and answer from the pair name alone.** If you cannot, that module needs another pass.
- **Watch for the inverted option.** Several of these scenarios offered the pair the wrong way round.
- **Two pairs in one question is the exam's favourite trick.** Knowing one and guessing the other lands you on a distractor.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Next: how Snowflake writes questions. Then three practice exams under timed conditions.